

more perfect Union, establish Justice, insure domestic Tranquility . . . promote the general Welfare, and secure the Blessings of Liberty to ourselves and our Posterity.” These commitments—especially to a *more perfect* Union, to *justice* for all, to domestic *tranquility*, and to the *general* welfare—are not mere words; they represent the challenge of our age.

In all, of course, Americans seem to have quite enough of the things that we can measure! With 4 percent of the world’s population, we produce 21 percent of the world’s output, consume 25 percent of it, and earn 26 percent of the world’s income. Our wealth is unsurpassed, as is our military might, although wars in far-off countries are consuming staggering amounts of our treasure. We continue to import far more from foreign lands than we export to them, the result of our *de minimis* national savings rate (as calculated by our government, about zero). The weakness of our U.S. dollar in world currency markets bodes ill for the future.

What’s more, the real growth rate of our economy—about 3 percent per year currently—lags far behind the growth rates of the emerging giants of China (9 percent) and India (6 percent). While these high rates of growth from a small base are unsustainable, we should be clear that our domination of the global economy—and the global financial markets on which that economy is ultimately based—will not endure forever.

But, in the spirit of the analysis that has permeated this book, while we seem to have quite enough things in the United States, our traditional values seem to be eroding, and soon we’ll not have nearly enough of them. So let’s never forget that over the long term it is not things, nor power, nor money that forms the heart of any nation. Rather, it is values, the very values, applied to our society, that I have described here for us as individuals: the persistence, resilience, moral standards, and virtue that have made this nation great. The question, in short, is not whether the United States has enough money—enough productive wealth—to maintain and enhance its global presence and power, but whether it has enough character, values, and virtue to do so. [26](#)